

Ha Long Bay

A large inlet into the Gulf of Tonkin, containing a scattering of hundreds of spectacular karst islands



Covering an area of about 600 square miles (1,500 square km) off the coast of Vietnam, Ha Long Bay was created about 8,000 years ago when sea-level rise drowned an existing karst landscape. Karst consists of limestone blocks that have been partially dissolved by rainwater over tens of millions of years. In tropical areas, it typically creates conical hills and towers with internal caves and sinkholes (see panel, right). When the sea flooded into Ha Long Bay, these hills and towers were turned into some 1,600 islands, most of which are fringed by vertical cliffs. There are hundreds of caves within the islands, but none is long or deep because their extent is limited by the



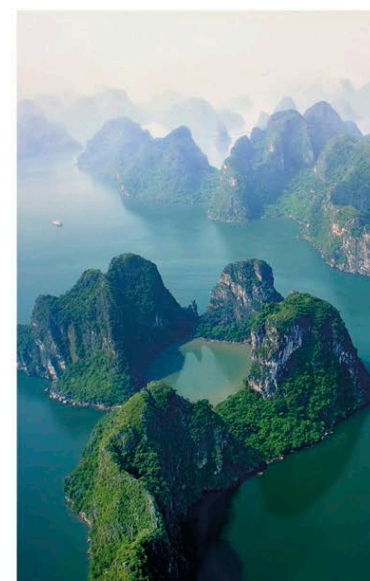
sizes of the islands. Because of their precipitous nature, most of the islands are uninhabited by humans. However, several communities live on the water in floating houses, sustaining themselves by fishing and aquaculture. The bay's shallow waters are biologically highly productive and support hundreds of species of fish, mollusks, and crustaceans. Animals living on the islands include lizards, monkeys, bats, and many bird species.

◁ PERILOUSLY LOW

Cat Ba, a relatively large island on the southwestern edge of the bay, is home to the Cat Ba langur, a critically endangered monkey, with a population estimated at less than 100.

△ INTRICATE SHORELINES

Many of the islands in the bay have convoluted shapes. Some have been given distinctive names, such as Man's Head Island, Rocky Dog, and Fighting Cocks Islet.



Some caves have **tunnels** leading into **inland lakes** that have **no other access**

